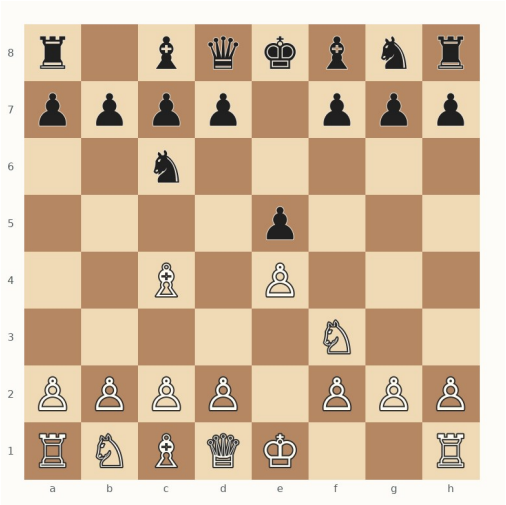
CHESS ACADEMY • COURSEBOOK 01

CHESS FROM 800 TO 1200

A practical course in openings, tactics, calculation and real-game improvement

Written for a returning player around the 800–1000 online rating range



The Italian Game after 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4

VOLUME 1 | 16 LESSONS | 24 PRACTICE QUESTIONS | COMPLETE ANSWER KEY

Original instruction informed by published chess courses and established opening references • November 2026

Welcome to the coursebook

This is a guided training book, not a catalog of traps. It starts from a realistic foundation for someone who has played chess before, reached roughly 1000 online, and wants to return to chess while understanding the openings that make the game interesting.

The goal is to develop skills you can apply when an opponent plays something unexpected. You will learn opening ideas, spot tactical patterns, calculate simple variations, and review games deliberately. Rating improvement is possible, but no particular rating gain is guaranteed.

WHAT THIS IS An original instructional synthesis based on the official curricula and opening references listed on the Sources pages. It does not reproduce a paid workbook or claim endorsement by the course providers.

A genuine course structure

- Read the lesson and explain the main idea in your own words.
- Replay the annotated opening sequence on a real board or Lichess analysis board.
- Complete the assigned workbook questions before opening the answer key.
- Write down one mistake and reattempt the relevant question on the next study day.
- Play a slow game and connect one idea from that game to the lesson.

What has been verified

All opening move sequences printed as model lines were checked for legal moves using a separate move generator. The definitions and named opening move orders were cross-checked against the cited references. Composed tactics diagrams are expressly labeled as training positions. The book does not claim independent engine proof of each position's optimality; where multiple reasonable moves exist, the task asks for an idea or a plausible move rather than a unique "best move."

Notation you will see

e4, d5	**A pawn moves to the named square.**
Nf3, Bc4	Knight and bishop moves.
Rxe8#	A rook captures on e8, giving checkmate.
O-O	Kingside castling.
...Bf5	A Black move, usually quoted without the preceding White move.
? / ! / ?!	In analysis, respectively a mistake, a good move, or a dubious move; context matters.

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24 questions • Answer key • Four-week study plan • Glossary • Sources

START HERE Read Lessons 1–5 first. If you already know a skill well, answer its related questions quickly and move forward. Keep practicing tactics while studying openings.

PART I · BUILD YOUR CHESS VISION

01 A thinking routine that prevents blunders

LEARNING TARGET Use checks, captures, threats and opponent-threat inspection before choosing a move.

Before searching for a clever idea, ask a practical question: What did the opponent's last move threaten? At the 800–1000 level, recognizing a loose piece or an immediate check is often more valuable than remembering an obscure opening variation.

Use a consistent scan: (1) Is my king safe? (2) What checks do either of us have? (3) What captures change the position? (4) What forcing threats are available? (5) Which of my pieces is unprotected or attacked more times than defended?

Then examine two or three candidate moves. For each, picture the opponent's strongest reply before committing. A move can obey an opening principle and still lose material to a tactic.

Before you move on

- Identify the opponent's threat.
- Check forcing moves before quiet moves.
- After choosing, imagine the strongest reply.

YOUR ASSIGNMENT Write your five-question scan on a card. Use it for at least ten moves in your next rapid game.

Theory / teaching references: S01, S09. Full source links appear at the end of the book.

PART I · BUILD YOUR CHESS VISION

02 Forks and double attacks

LEARNING TARGET Recognize one move that attacks two targets, and check whether the attacker can be captured.

A fork is a single move that creates two or more attacks. Knights are famous for forks because their L-shaped moves can attack a king and a rook or queen at once. Pawns, queens, rooks and bishops can also make double attacks.

Do not assume every fork wins. A fork only matters if the forked targets cannot escape together and the attacking piece survives long enough to benefit. Always ask: Can the opponent capture the forking piece, give check, or create a stronger threat?

In our composed example, a knight can jump into c7 with check, attacking the black king on e8 and rook on a8. The check forces a response; afterward the rook is vulnerable.

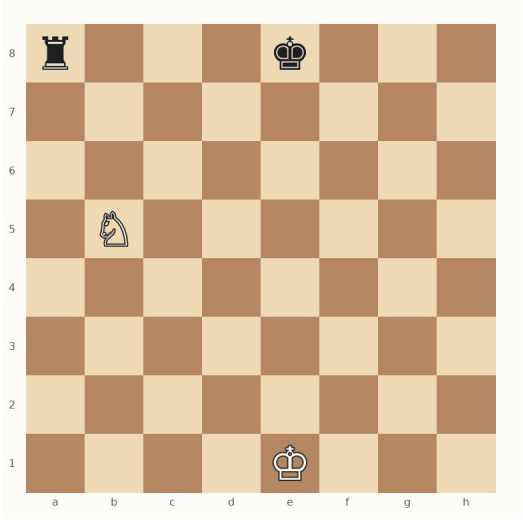


Diagram: a composed knight-fork exercise. White to move.

WORKED EXAMPLE Find Nc7+ in the diagram. It checks the black king and attacks the rook. Notice how a forcing move can win time.

Before you move on

- Look for knight jumps near kings and major pieces.
- Calculate the response to the check.
- Do not confuse “attacks two things” with “wins two things.”

YOUR ASSIGNMENT Workbook P01 is the same motif without the answer on the exercise page.

Theory / teaching references: S01, S09. Full source links appear at the end of the book.

PART I · BUILD YOUR CHESS VISION

03 Pins, skewers and discovered checks

LEARNING TARGET Separate three related line-piece motifs and calculate their consequences.

A pin happens when moving a front piece would expose a more valuable piece behind it. An absolute pin exposes the king, so the pinned piece cannot legally leave the line. A relative pin exposes a queen or other material: moving is legal, but often costly.

A skewer reverses the order: a more valuable piece is attacked first and must usually move, exposing a less valuable piece behind it. A discovered attack occurs when one piece moves away and reveals an attack from a rook, bishop, or queen.

Double check is a special form of discovered check in which two pieces check the king at once. The checked side must move the king; blocking or capturing only one checking piece cannot solve both checks.

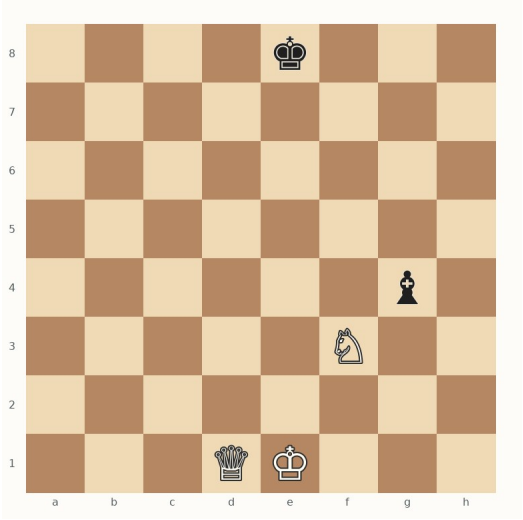


Diagram: the bishop on g4 pins White's knight on f3 to White's queen on d1.

WORKED EXAMPLE Here the knight is relatively pinned: moving away can expose the queen to the bishop. This is not an absolute pin because the piece behind it is a queen, not the king.

Before you move on

- Name the front and rear targets on every line.
- For a discovered check, identify both checking lines.
- A pin against the queen is not the same as an illegal move.

YOUR ASSIGNMENT Workbook P02–P04 test a pin, skewer and discovered double check.

Theory / teaching references: S01, S09. Full source links appear at the end of the book.

PART I · BUILD YOUR CHESS VISION

04 King safety and mating patterns

LEARNING TARGET Recognize why back-rank mates work, and how to create an escape square.

A king with friendly pawns on f7, g7 and h7 (for Black) can be trapped on the back rank. If an enemy rook reaches that rank with check, the king may have no escape square. A back-rank mate requires checking whether the defender can capture the rook, block the line, or respond with another legal move.

When you are defending, consider a timely luft move such as ...h6 or h3 (depending on color and position) to create an escape square. Do not push pawns automatically: pawn moves can also create weaknesses.

Learn the geometry first, then solve mixed tactical positions so you no longer know the theme in advance. This mirrors the progression from pattern recognition to calculation.

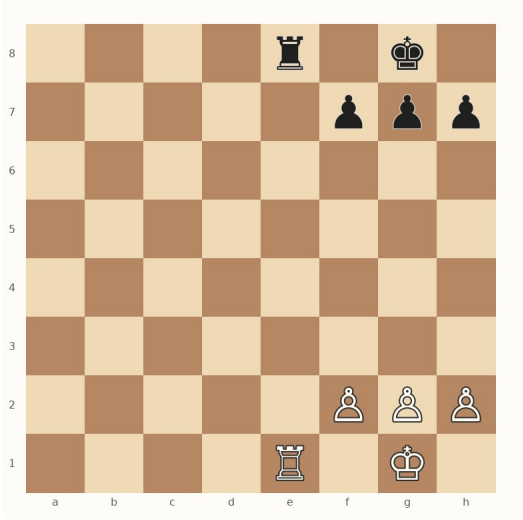


Diagram: a composed back-rank mate in one for White.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rxe8# works in the diagram: the white rook captures the opposing rook and gives mate along the eighth rank, while Black's own pawns block the king's exits.

Before you move on

- Does the king have a flight square?
- Can the rook be captured or the check blocked?
- Before pushing a pawn, consider new weaknesses.

YOUR ASSIGNMENT Workbook P05 asks you to find the back-rank finish.

Theory / teaching references: S09, S11. Full source links appear at the end of the book.

PART II · UNDERSTAND OPENINGS

05 Opening priorities, not opening commandments

LEARNING TARGET Explain central control, development, king safety, and tempo in plain language.

Opening theory is the body of tested plans and move sequences for reaching playable middlegames. Beginners need its ideas before its long variations: fight for e4, d4, e5 and d5; develop pieces to active squares; safeguard the king; and avoid losing time or material.

A useful rule of thumb is to bring minor pieces into play before repeatedly moving the queen or the same piece. But this is not a law: a forced recapture, a tactical opportunity or a response to a threat is more important than a slogan.

The practical goal is not to “win the opening” on move six. It is to reach a middlegame with coordinated pieces, a reasonably safe king, and a plan. After move ten, compare your development and king safety with your opponent’s, as a documented opening study plan recommends.

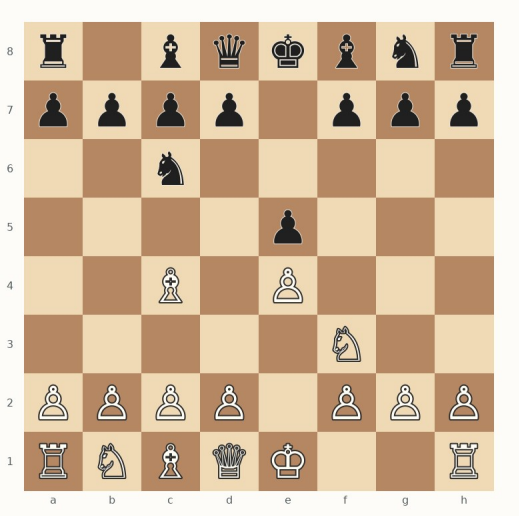


Diagram: the Italian Game after the first five half-moves.

WORKED EXAMPLE White’s knight on f3 develops with a threat to e5; the bishop on c4 points toward f7. Black’s knight c6 defends e5. Every move has a purpose.

Before you move on

- Who controls the center?
- Which minor pieces remain on original squares?
- Which king can castle safely?

YOUR ASSIGNMENT Workbook P06 asks you to explain the purpose of Bc4, not merely name it.

Theory / teaching references: S03, S05, S11. Full source links appear at the end of the book.

PART II · UNDERSTAND OPENINGS

06 Diagnose an opening after move ten

LEARNING TARGET Make a simple scorecard rather than judging only by material.

Use a four-part opening scorecard: center, development, king safety and immediate threats. Do not give yourself a “good opening” just because you followed memorized moves; look at the position you reached.

Count undeveloped knights and bishops. Ask whether any pawn is attacked without enough defenders and whether your king is stuck in the center while files are opening. Finally, identify one useful next move: improve a piece, support the center, or castle.

Measuring opening success this way helps when opponents leave your prepared lines. Opening understanding is the ability to handle unfamiliar replies, not to force the opponent into your favorite variation.

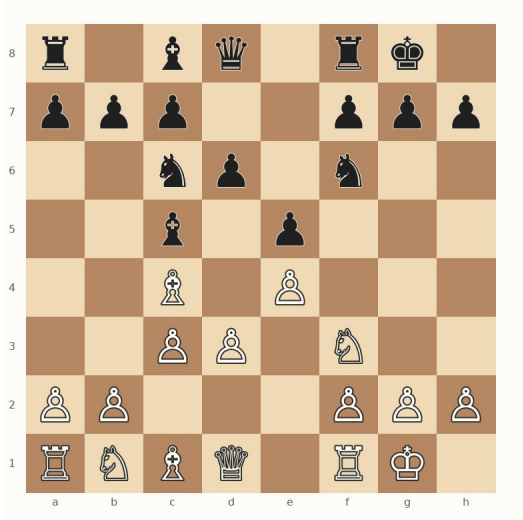


Diagram: a possible Italian structure after both players have castled.

WORKED EXAMPLE In this model, both sides have some development and king safety. White can consider Re1 and Nbd2, aiming for a later central expansion; this is a plan, not a forced line.

Before you move on

- Can I name one concrete weakness?
- Can I explain my next two useful moves?
- What would my opponent like to play?

YOUR ASSIGNMENT After each practice game, save the position around move ten and score all four categories.

Theory / teaching references: S03, S04, S05. Full source links appear at the end of the book.

PART III · AN OPENING REPERTOIRE

07 Italian Game: the quiet foundation

LEARNING TARGET Learn the first three moves and one strategic setup for White.

The Italian Game begins 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4. It is a classical king-pawn opening that combines natural development with tactical pressure against f7. White's bishop on c4 attacks along the diagonal toward that pawn; in the initial position f7 is defended only by Black's king.

After 3...Bc5, the Giuoco Piano family has many playable paths. For a first repertoire, the calm setup with c3, d3, O-O, Re1 and Nbd2 is easier to understand than memorizing a sharp gambit. Your long-term central idea is often d4 when it is well prepared.

Do not copy the plan against every move without thinking. If Black threatens e4, you must defend or calculate the pawn. If Black strikes the center, reassess before developing automatically.

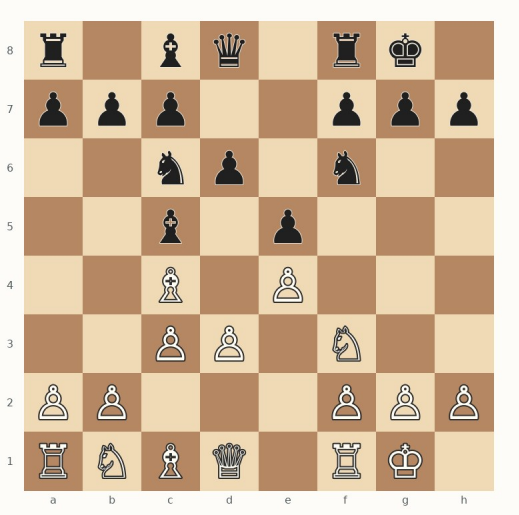


Diagram: a representative Italian line: 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Bc5 4.c3 Nf6 5.d3 d6 6.O-O O-O.

WORKED EXAMPLE The model position is symmetrical. White has a solid center and may develop Re1 and Nbd2. Black can answer with their own useful development. Neither side is "winning by theory."

Before you move on

- Memorize 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4.
- Understand why c3 and d3 serve different purposes.
- Castling is a strategic goal, not an excuse to ignore tactics.

YOUR ASSIGNMENT Replay the model without notes, then explain each white move in one sentence.

Theory / teaching references: S05, S03. Full source links appear at the end of the book.

PART III · AN OPENING REPERTOIRE

08 Italian Game: central break and open lines

LEARNING TARGET Understand when c3 and d4 increase White's activity.

In the Italian, c3 can support d4. The break d4 challenges Black's central pawn on e5, may attack a bishop on c5, and may open files and diagonals after exchanges. The cost is time and a more complicated position.

Consider the illustrative continuation 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Bc5 4.c3 Nf6 5.d4 exd4 6.cxd4 Bb4+ 7.Nc3. This shows how a central advance can lead immediately to a check and the need for concrete calculation.

A playable plan is not a guarantee of advantage. When you consider d4, count defenders of e4 and d4, look for ...exd4, and ask whether Black has a tactical reply such as ...Bb4+.

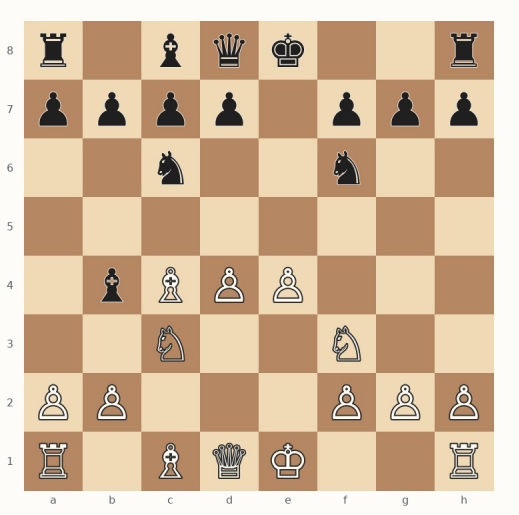


Diagram: the Italian after 7.Nc3 in a concrete central-exchange example.

WORKED EXAMPLE The move 7.Nc3 blocks the bishop's check while developing a knight. The resulting position is active and tactical; it requires more calculation than the quiet d3 plan.

Before you move on

- Before d4, identify Black's capturing replies.
- Notice checks created by opening the center.
- Accept that opening lines branch, rather than following one script.

YOUR ASSIGNMENT Workbook P07 tests the central break; P08 asks you to answer a forcing check.

Theory / teaching references: S05. Full source links appear at the end of the book.

PART III · AN OPENING REPERTOIRE

09 Italian Game: attacking f7 with care

LEARNING TARGET Recognize the Two Knights position and distinguish an idea from a trap.

After 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Nf6, Black attacks e4 and the position is called the Two Knights Defense. One sharp White choice is 4.Ng5, aiming at f7. Black has a principled defense with 4...d5. After 5.exd5 the position is already theory-rich.

An important practical lesson: pressure on f7 does not automatically mean an immediate winning capture. If you study a famous tactical pattern, learn the defender's best resource. In the Two Knights, the line with ...Na5 differs significantly from ...Nxd5, so memorizing a one-move trap is not enough.

For your current level, the quiet 4.d3 is also a perfectly usable practical choice. Keep both ideas in your toolkit: 4.d3 to develop calmly, and 4.Ng5 only when prepared to calculate the critical center response.

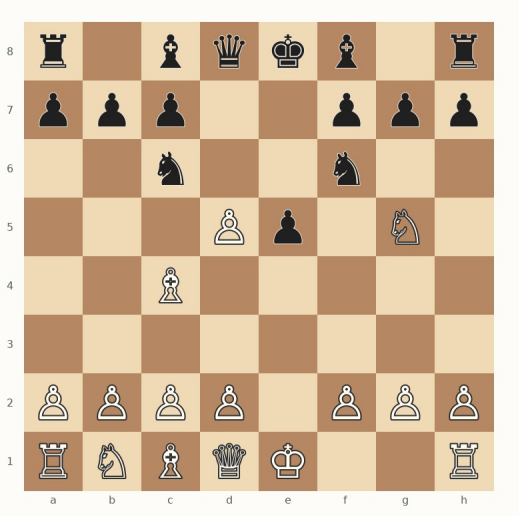


Diagram: 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Nf6 4.Ng5 d5 5.exd5.

WORKED EXAMPLE The point is not that White has already won: Black must respond accurately. Compare 5...Na5 (a principal defensive approach) with the tempting 5...Nxd5?! (riskier due to tactical ideas).

Before you move on

- When one side attacks f7, look for central counterplay.
- Know what ...d5 changes in the position.
- Choose a calm line when you cannot yet calculate a sharp one.

YOUR ASSIGNMENT Workbook P09 asks you to identify the important response to Ng5.

Theory / teaching references: S05, S09. Full source links appear at the end of the book.

PART IV · PLAYING BLACK AGAINST 1.e4

10 Caro-Kann: why ...c6 supports ...d5

LEARNING TARGET Build a Black repertoire around the central challenge and active bishop.

The Caro-Kann Defense begins 1.e4 c6. Black prepares ...d5, directly challenging White's central e4 pawn. Unlike a French Defense setup with an early ...e6, the Caro-Kann often lets the light-squared bishop develop outside the pawn chain before ...e6.

A standard Classical line is 1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Bf5 5.Ng3 Bg6. Here ...Bf5 is not a random bishop move: Black develops while attacking the knight on e4. White gains tempos against the bishop in some variations, so Black must know retreat squares and not blindly chase pawns.

Your practical priority with Black is to complete development, preserve a healthy center, and find an appropriate pawn break. The Caro-Kann can be solid but is not tactically automatic or always easy.

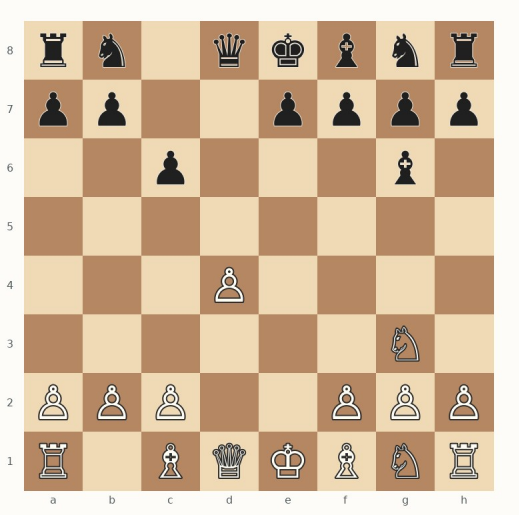


Diagram: Classical Caro-Kann after 5...Bg6.

WORKED EXAMPLE White has more central space and may attack the bishop. Black has exchanged the central e-pawn and developed the light-squared bishop. Learn the trade-off, not just the sequence.

Before you move on

- After 1.e4, answer 1...c6 and plan ...d5.
- In the Classical, understand ...dxe4, ...Bf5, ...Bg6.
- Stay alert to kingside expansion by White.

YOUR ASSIGNMENT Workbook P10 asks which bishop-development move defines the Classical plan.

Theory / teaching references: S06, S12. Full source links appear at the end of the book.

PART IV · PLAYING BLACK AGAINST 1.e4

11 Caro-Kann: Advance and Exchange choices

LEARNING TARGET Recognize two common deviations from the Classical line.

White may play 3.e5 rather than exchange. In the Advance Variation (1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.e5), White gains space, while Black generally looks for pressure against the pawn center. A typical development choice is 3...Bf5, followed later by ...e6 and a carefully timed ...c5.

White may instead choose 3.exd5, the Exchange Variation. Black usually answers ...cxd5, recapturing toward the center and developing normally. An example is 1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.Bd3 Nc6 5.c3 Nf6 6.Bf4.

Your decision tree can stay small: against 3.Nc3 or 3.Nd2, learn the Classical response; against 3.e5, understand ...Bf5 and pressure on d4; against 3.exd5, recapture with the c-pawn and develop. Other sidelines exist and need later expansion.

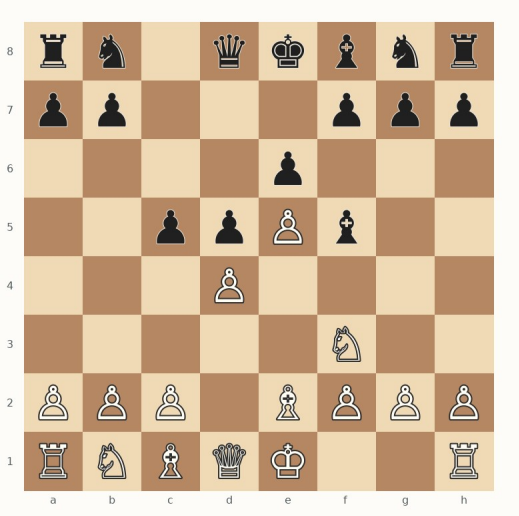


Diagram: Advance Caro-Kann after ...c5, illustrating counterplay against White's center.

WORKED EXAMPLE Black's c-pawn has advanced from c6 to c5, challenging the base of White's pawn chain at d4. The best timing depends on the position; this is a model plan.

Before you move on

- Advance: White's e5 pawn gains space.
- Exchange: the c-pawn often recaptures on d5.
- Plans matter more than memorizing every sideline.

YOUR ASSIGNMENT Workbook P11 and P12 test the Advance and Exchange structures.

Theory / teaching references: S06. Full source links appear at the end of the book.

PART V · PLAYING BLACK AGAINST 1.d4

12 Queen's Gambit Declined: the central skeleton

LEARNING TARGET Understand why 1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 is a respected Black setup.

The Queen's Gambit Declined (QGD) begins 1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6. White uses the c-pawn to challenge Black's central d5 pawn. Black declines the gambit by supporting d5 with e6 instead of taking on c4.

A classical Orthodox setup runs 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bg5 Be7 5.e3 O-O 6.Nf3 Nbd7. Black is solid, gets the king safe, and retains the central d5 pawn; the light-squared bishop on c8 can take more work to activate.

Black frequently seeks a later ...c5 pawn break to attack White's d4 pawn. Learn the strategic relationship: White presses in the center and can gain space; Black resists and looks for a freeing break. This is not a rigid response to every 1.d4 system.

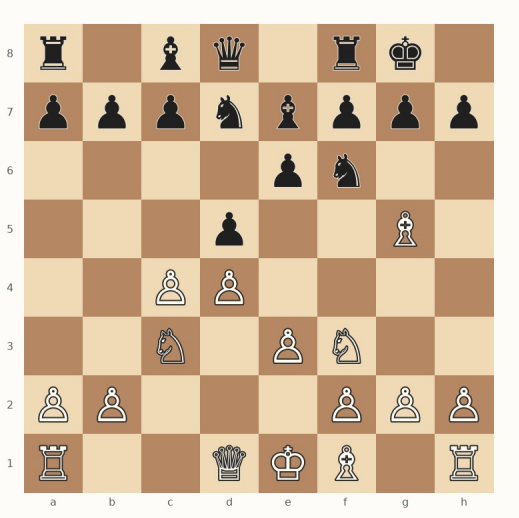


Diagram: the published Orthodox QGD move order through 6...Nbd7.

WORKED EXAMPLE Black has castled and developed both kingside pieces; the c8 bishop remains behind its e6 pawn. A common long-term goal is freeing play with ...c5.

Before you move on

- Identify why ...e6 defends d5.
- Notice the c8 bishop's development problem.
- Know that ...c5 is a common idea, not a move to force instantly.

YOUR ASSIGNMENT Workbook P13 and P14 test QGD structure and plans.

Theory / teaching references: S07, S08, S13. Full source links appear at the end of the book.

PART VI · FROM THE OPENING TO A PLAN

13 A practical middlegame planning method

LEARNING TARGET Translate a position into one clear, testable plan.

When you leave your prepared opening, do not panic. List the imbalances: king safety, central control, material, pawn weaknesses, open files, active pieces and vulnerable squares. You do not need an elaborate master-level evaluation; choose the two factors that matter most.

If a piece is badly placed, improve it. If the center is stable, prepare a pawn break. If your opponent has a loose piece, consider whether a forcing tactical move exists. If your king is unsafe, repairing that problem usually takes priority.

A practical question for every move is “What changes after this move?” For example, in the quiet Italian, Re1 may support e4 and prepare a later d4; in the QGD, ...c5 can contest White’s pawn center. Neither is always best without checking the concrete position.



Diagram: a representative developed QGD structure to evaluate.

WORKED EXAMPLE From Black’s side, identify the developed minor pieces and the remaining c8 bishop. Ask whether a later ...c5 or ...e5 break is feasible and what White threatens in response.

Before you move on

- Name a worst-placed piece on each side.
- Look for pawn breaks and open files.
- Check tactics before carrying out a positional plan.

YOUR ASSIGNMENT After a rapid game, annotate one moment where you had no idea what to do.

Theory / teaching references: S01, S03, S13. Full source links appear at the end of the book.

PART VI · FROM THE OPENING TO A PLAN

14 Calculation and comparing candidate moves

LEARNING TARGET Calculate forcing replies before selecting your favorite move.

Try a three-stage method: first list two or three plausible candidate moves; second analyze checks, captures and direct threats in each line; third compare the resulting positions. Avoid stopping at “my move threatens the queen” when your opponent can answer with checkmate.

When you solve a puzzle, write what your opponent would do after your move. If your analysis relies on the opponent making a blunder, look for a stronger defense. A correct pattern noticed for the wrong reason is not yet reliable knowledge.

In real games, you will not have perfect engine certainty. Your goal is disciplined thinking. Keep a small error log: missed checks, hanging pieces, calculation too shallow, or opening move forgotten. Make next week’s drills respond to those errors.

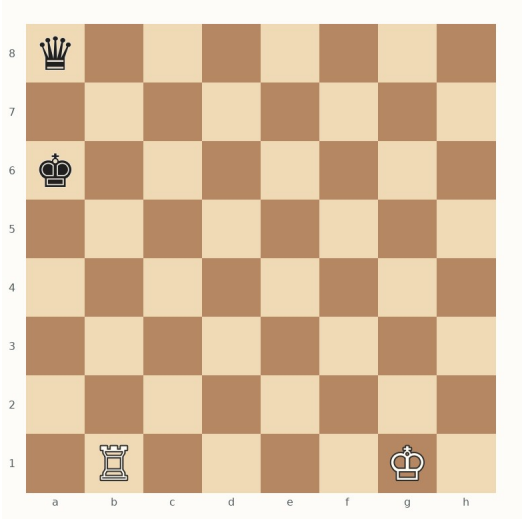


Diagram: a forcing check opens a tactical opportunity.

WORKED EXAMPLE In this composed position, Ra1+ skewers the black king in front of the queen. The critical idea is the forced king response, after which the rook can take the queen if no stronger defense intervenes.

Before you move on

- Analyze the opponent’s most forcing reply.
- Stop calculating only when the position is quiet enough to evaluate.
- Record the cause of errors, not just the engine move.

YOUR ASSIGNMENT Workbook P15–P17 ask you to calculate simple forcing sequences.

Theory / teaching references: S01, S09. Full source links appear at the end of the book.

PART VII · ENDGAMES AND PRACTICAL GROWTH

15 King and pawn endings: opposition and pawn races

LEARNING TARGET Understand the active king, opposition, and the square rule.

Endgames reward precision. A king becomes a fighting piece, and a passed pawn can become the main plan. Opposition means two kings face each other with one square between them on a rank or file, with the side NOT to move usually having the immediate opposition.

Opposition is a tool, not a universal guarantee of a win: pawns, board edges and whose turn it is still matter. In pawn races, the square rule gives a quick first check of whether an enemy king can catch a passed pawn; count the pawn's moves to promotion and compare the defending king's distance.

Practice these positions without an engine first. Afterward, test your reasoning on a board and check exact legal moves. Even a basic grasp of endgames improves decisions in earlier phases: you will know when simplification helps.

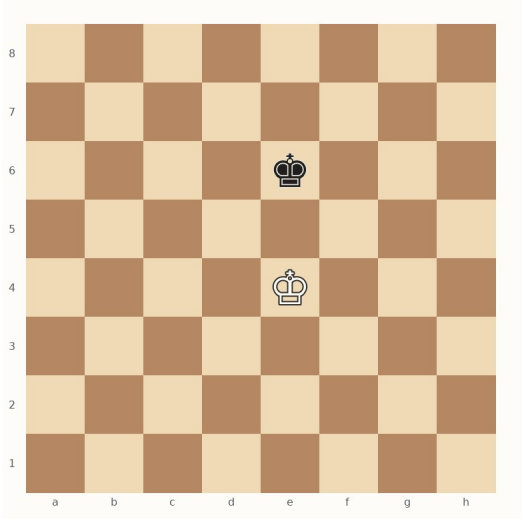


Diagram: kings on e4 and e6, Black to move. White has the immediate opposition.

WORKED EXAMPLE Since Black is to move, Black must step away from the direct face-off. This diagram teaches the definition; with no pawns present, it is a draw, not a winning endgame claim.

Before you move on

- Activate the king when safe.
- Remember: having opposition is not the same as winning.
- Count pawn tempi carefully.

YOUR ASSIGNMENT Workbook P18 and P19 cover opposition and a simple pawn race.

Theory / teaching references: S01, S11. Full source links appear at the end of the book.

PART VII · ENDGAMES AND PRACTICAL GROWTH

16 How to study and review your real games

LEARNING TARGET Build a repeatable improvement loop rather than guessing what to study.

Play at a time control that permits deliberate thought, such as 15+10 when you have time. Immediately afterward, mark three moments: the first move you did not understand, the first significant tactical mistake, and one moment you struggled to choose a plan.

Analyze without an engine for a few minutes. Write a candidate move and the response you feared. Only then compare with computer analysis. An engine can identify tactical flaws, but you still need to explain the idea in ordinary words.

Use spaced retrieval for openings: play the line from memory the next day, again after several days, then again the following week. When you forget a move, revisit the position and the underlying plan. A short, maintained repertoire is better than a huge set of lines you cannot use.

Before you move on

- For every game record one opening lesson, one tactical lesson, one planning lesson.
- Use an engine to check your explanation, not replace it.
- Revisit missed exercises on a longer schedule.

YOUR ASSIGNMENT Complete the 4-week plan and final assessment at the end of this book.

Theory / teaching references: S03, S04, S10. Full source links appear at the end of the book.

PART VIII · PRACTICE & REFERENCE

Workbook | 24 questions

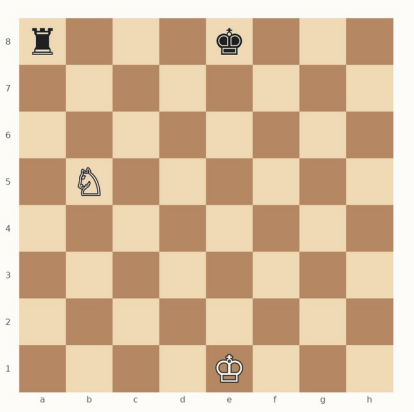
Try the exercises without looking at the solutions. For diagram exercises, the board shows the position before the move. These are training snapshots or clearly composed positions, not claims about complete historical games. A chess engine is not required to solve them.

SCORING Award yourself 1 point per question for a correct idea and a valid explanation. For P07, other sound moves are accepted when justified; for conceptual questions, equivalent accurate wording counts. Work through 24 questions, then identify recurring error types.

P01 Position exercise

White to move. Find the knight move that checks Black and attacks the rook on a8.

Explain your reasoning before checking the answer.

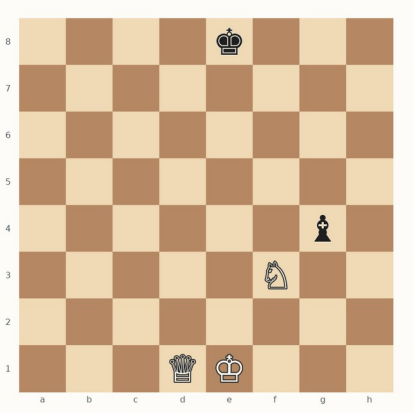


White to move

P02 Position exercise

White to move. Explain why moving the knight from f3 can lose material. Is it an absolute pin?

Explain your reasoning before checking the answer.

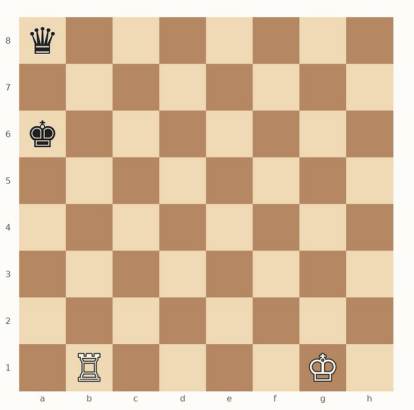


White to move

P03 Position exercise

White to move. Find a rook check that attacks the queen only after the king moves.

Explain your reasoning before checking the answer.

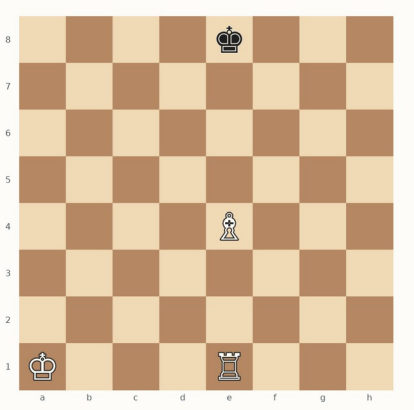


White to move

P04 Position exercise

White to move. Find a bishop move that delivers a double check.

Explain your reasoning before checking the answer.

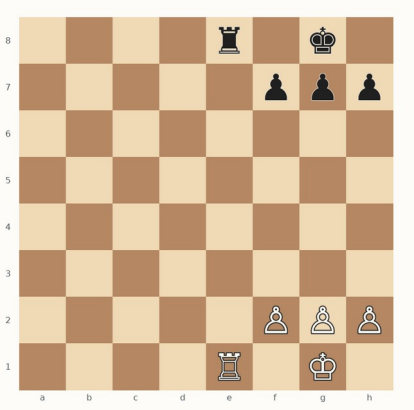


White to move

P05 Position exercise

White to move. Find mate in one. State why the king has no flight square.

Explain your reasoning before checking the answer.



White to move

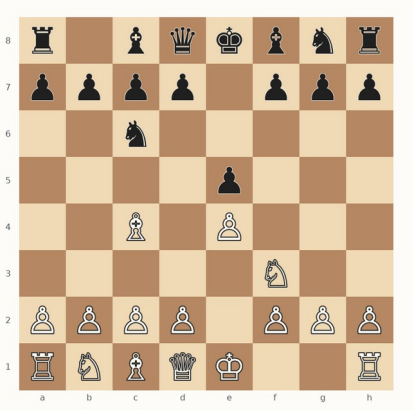
REVIEW POINT Pause here and check whether you can state the relevant tactical or opening idea without looking at the previous lessons.

Opening reasoning

P06 Position exercise

What two jobs does 3.Bc4 accomplish for White in this position?

Explain your reasoning before checking the answer.

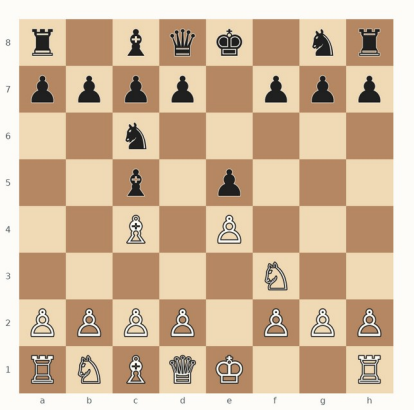


Black to move

P07 Position exercise

White to move. Name one quiet preparatory move and describe its purpose.

Explain your reasoning before checking the answer.

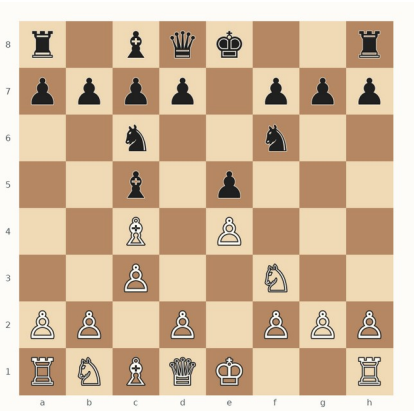


White to move

P08 Position exercise

White to move. What does 5.d4 challenge? Name a possible Black capture.

Explain your reasoning before checking the answer.

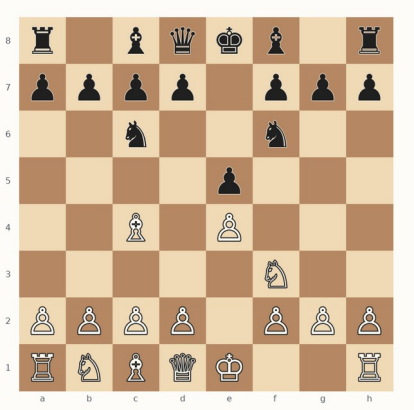


White to move

P09 Position exercise

Black has just played ...Nf6. What White pawn is attacked, and give one calm defensive move.

Explain your reasoning before checking the answer.



White to move

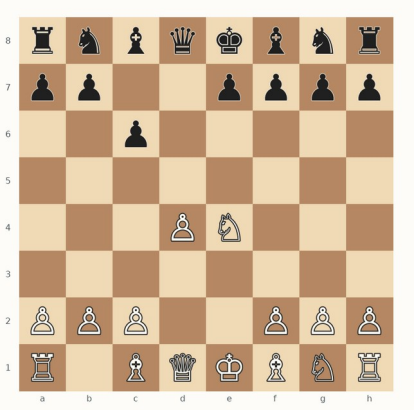
REVIEW POINT Pause here and check whether you can state the relevant tactical or opening idea without looking at the previous lessons.

Playing Black

P10 Position exercise

Black to move. Which development move begins the Classical Caro-Kann variation?

Explain your reasoning before checking the answer.

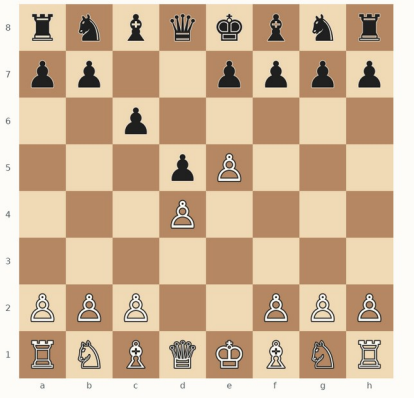


Black to move

P11 Position exercise

Black to move. Which natural bishop development move is typical in the Caro-Kann Advance?

Explain your reasoning before checking the answer.

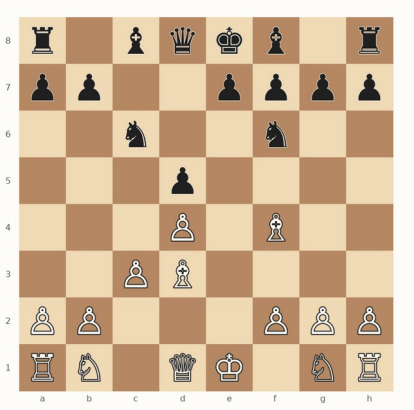


Black to move

P12 Position exercise

Which pawn recaptured on d5 in this Exchange Caro-Kann, and why does it make positional sense?

Explain your reasoning before checking the answer.

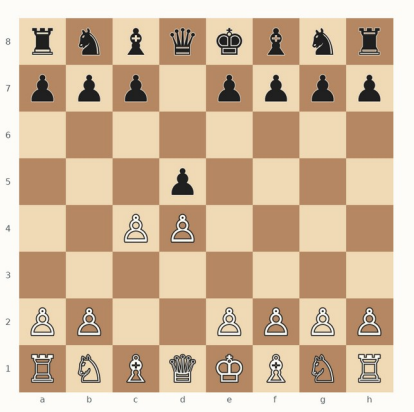


Black to move

P13 Position exercise

Black to move. What move defines the Queen's Gambit Declined?

Explain your reasoning before checking the answer.

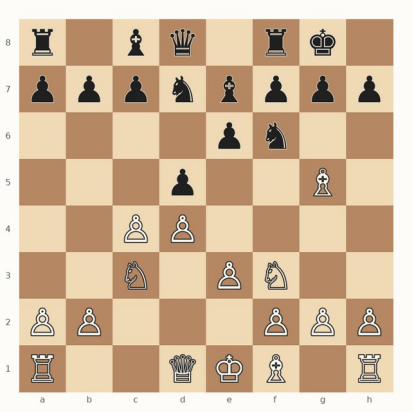


Black to move

P14 Position exercise

Name the Black light-squared bishop's main development difficulty in this Orthodox QGD.

Explain your reasoning before checking the answer.



White to move

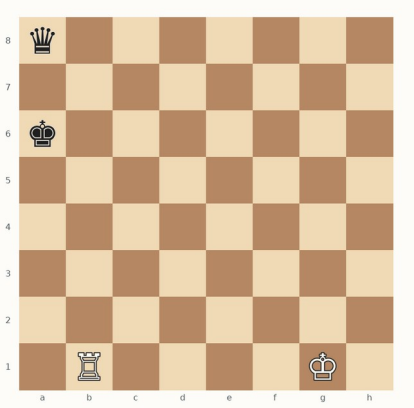
REVIEW POINT Pause here and check whether you can state the relevant tactical or opening idea without looking at the previous lessons.

Calculate forcing moves

P15 Position exercise

Calculate the first move. Why is it more forcing than a quiet rook move?

Explain your reasoning before checking the answer.

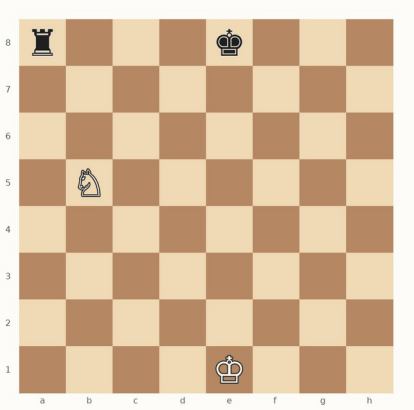


White to move

P16 Position exercise

If White plays Nc7+, which valuable Black piece besides the king comes under attack?

Explain your reasoning before checking the answer.

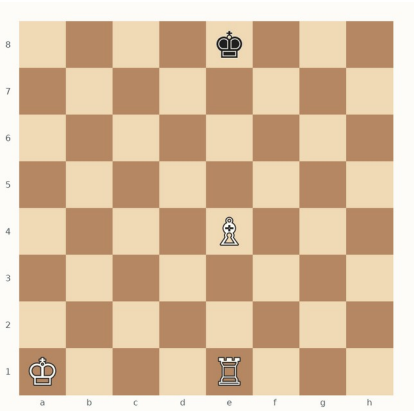


White to move

P17 Position exercise

After Bg6+, why can Black not simply block the e-file check with one piece?

Explain your reasoning before checking the answer.

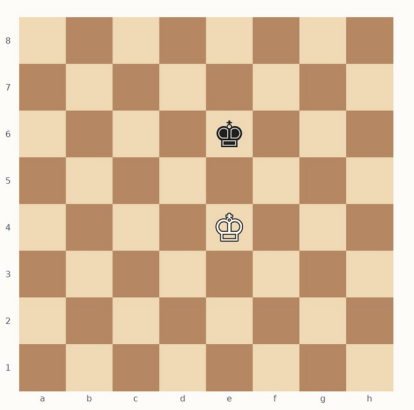


White to move

P18 Position exercise

It is Black's move. Which king has the immediate opposition, and does that alone prove a win?

Explain your reasoning before checking the answer.

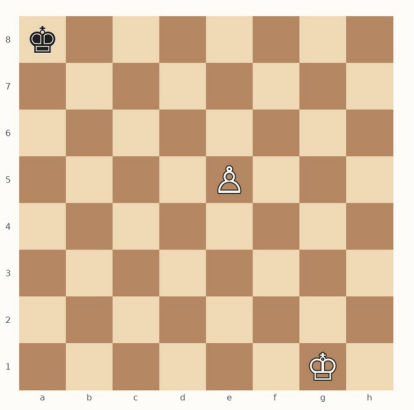


Black to move

P19 Position exercise

White to move with a pawn on e5. Is the black king on a8 close enough to stop the pawn without help?

Explain your reasoning before checking the answer.



White to move

REVIEW POINT Pause here and check whether you can state the relevant tactical or opening idea without looking at the previous lessons.

Written understanding

P20 Written exercise

After 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4, name two plausible Black third moves and what each creates.

Your answer: _____

_____

P21 Written exercise

After 1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.e5, what square is the base of White's pawn chain, and which pawn break often challenges it?

Your answer: _____

_____

P22 Written exercise

After 1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6, what long-term pawn break does Black often seek, and what is its purpose?

Your answer: _____

_____

P23 Written exercise

Your opponent makes a move you have never studied on move four. State a three-question opening response instead of guessing a memorized line.

Your answer: _____

_____

P24 Written exercise

You lost a rapid game in the opening. List three useful notes before turning on the engine.

Your answer: _____

_____

Answer key | Explain the reason

These model solutions give the main idea rather than only a move. In a real game, calculate counterplay and legality. Some workbook tasks are about identifying a sound plan, not claiming the only engine-approved move.

P01

1.Nc7+ (b5-c7). The check forces attention to the king; the knight also attacks the rook on a8.

P02

The bishop on g4 attacks the knight on f3, with White's queen on d1 behind it along g4-f3-e2-d1. It is a relative pin because moving the knight is legal but exposes the queen.

P03

1.Ra1+ is a skewer: the black king on a6 is between the attacking rook and the queen on a8. After the king moves, the rook threatens to take the queen.

P04

1.Bg6+ uncovers the e-file for the white rook and makes the bishop attack e8 through f7. Both rook and bishop check the king.

P05

1.Rxe8#. The rook checks along the eighth rank. Black's f7, g7 and h7 pawns trap the king, and the check cannot be met.

P06

It develops the bishop actively and puts pressure on the f7 square. The bishop also helps White prepare to castle kingside.

P07

4.c3 is one valid preparatory move toward d4; 4.d3 is another sound quiet choice that supports e4. The point is to know which plan each supports.

P08

5.d4 challenges the e5 pawn and also attacks the bishop on c5. Black can respond 5...exd4. The central change must be calculated.

P09

The knight f6 attacks White's e4 pawn. 4.d3 supports e4 while keeping a quiet Italian setup; 4.Ng5 is an alternative sharp continuation, not a defensive move.

P10

4...Bf5. Black develops the light-squared bishop outside the pawn chain and attacks White's knight on e4.

P11

3...Bf5. Black develops the light-squared bishop while preparing later pressure on the base of White's pawn center, d4.

P12

Black's c-pawn captured from c6 to d5. This keeps a central pawn on d5 and opens the c-file for Black's pieces.

P13

2...e6, defending Black's pawn on d5 instead of capturing the white pawn on c4.

P14

Black's bishop on c8 is hemmed in by the e6 pawn. Black often needs careful development or a pawn break to activate it.

P15

Ra1+ gives check immediately. The opponent must resolve the check before pursuing their own threats, so the rook can win time to attack the queen.

P16

The rook on a8. The key is not only seeing the fork but noticing that Black must first answer the check.

P17

Because Black is checked by both the rook on e1 and bishop on g6. Blocking one line does not end the other check; a king move is required.

P18

White has the opposition: the kings are two squares apart on the e-file and Black moves next. With no pawns in this diagram the position is a draw.

P19

No. The pawn needs three advances to promote and the black king is too far away. White can begin e6, e7, e8=Q if unopposed; check king safety when testing any race.

P20

3...Bc5 enters the Giuoco Piano family; 3...Nf6 enters the Two Knights Defense and attacks e4.

P21

The pawn on d4 is the base. Black often prepares ...c5 to challenge that base.

P22

...c5 is a common break that challenges White's d4 pawn and contests the center. It must be timed to the position.

P23

Ask what the move threatens, whether either side has forcing tactics, and which developing or central move improves your position safely. Other equivalent sound checklists are acceptable.

P24

Record the first surprising move, one tactical mistake or missed threat, and your intended plan or candidate move. Then check these ideas against analysis.

Four-week guided schedule

This schedule is adjustable. Plan about 30–45 minutes on five study days each week. Every session includes at least some real chess: solve, replay, or play. Revisit difficult material after 1, 3, 7 and 14 days as a simple adaptation of spaced repetition.

WEEK 1 · Build tactical sight

Day 1	**Lessons 1–2; solve P01 and P16.**
Day 2	Lessons 3–4; solve P02–P05.
Day 3	Play 15+10 rapid; analyze missed checks and captures.
Day 4	Redo wrong puzzles without hints; solve 5 Lichess fork/pin puzzles.
Day 5	Lesson 5; solve P06, then evaluate a game after move ten.

WEEK 2 · Italian as White

Day 1	**Lesson 6, compare 2 game positions on move ten.**
Day 2	Lesson 7; replay the quiet Italian line from memory.
Day 3	Lesson 8; solve P07–P08; play an Italian rapid game.
Day 4	Lesson 9; solve P09 and opening-themed Lichess puzzles.
Day 5	Play and review one or two slower games; write one improvement note.

WEEK 3 · Reliable setups as Black

Day 1	**Lesson 10; practice Classical Caro-Kann, solve P10.**
Day 2	Lesson 11; compare Advance and Exchange; solve P11–P12.
Day 3	Lesson 12; replay Orthodox QGD; solve P13–P14.

Day 4	Play Black games against 1.e4 and 1.d4; review the first unfamiliar move.
Day 5	Mixed recall of Italian, Caro-Kann and QGD with no written notes.

WEEK 4 • Play better chess

Day 1	**Lesson 13; annotate a plan from one recent game.**
Day 2	Lesson 14; solve P15–P17 and check forcing replies.
Day 3	Lesson 15; solve P18–P19 on a real board.
Day 4	Lesson 16; answer P20–P24 and analyze a slow game.
Day 5	Retake missed questions; repeat opening lines from memory; assess next steps.

Suggested Lichess practice links

Puzzle themes: https://lichess.org/training/themes

Italian Game tactics: https://lichess.org/training/Italian_Game

Caro-Kann tactics: https://lichess.org/training/Caro-Kann_Defense

Queen's Gambit Declined tactics: https://lichess.org/training/Queens_Gambit_Declined

Analysis board: https://lichess.org/analysis

Studies: https://lichess.org/study

Progress log | Track understanding, not just rating

For each study session, complete one line. Notice repeated mistakes and train that category next. Your goal is consistent decisions under pressure, not an arbitrary number of solved puzzles.

Date	Lesson / game	What I missed	Next review

End-of-volume self-assessment

- ☐ Can I explain the Italian Game through move three without a memorized script?
- ☐ Can I describe a quiet Italian setup and a tactical central break?
- ☐ Can I identify the main Classical, Advance, and Exchange Caro-Kann decisions?
- ☐ Can I explain why Black plays ...e6 in the Queen's Gambit Declined?
- ☐ Do I check forcing moves and opponent threats before every move?
- ☐ Can I give a plausible plan in an unfamiliar middlegame?
- ☐ Can I identify when a pawn race succeeds and who has immediate opposition?

NEXT STEP If your answers are consistently yes, build a deeper Italian repertoire, add replies to non-1...e5 defenses, and begin systematic endgame study. If not, return to the matching lesson and reattempt the relevant drills.

Chess vocabulary | Quick reference

Candidate move One of a few plausible moves considered before calculation.

Center The key central squares e4, d4, e5, d5, and their surrounding influence.

Development Bringing pieces from their starting squares to active, useful squares.

Tempo A move or unit of time; a move with a threat may gain time.

Pawn break Advancing a pawn to challenge a pawn chain or open lines.

Fork A move that attacks two or more targets.

Pin A front piece is tied to a more valuable piece behind it.

Skewer A more valuable piece is attacked and exposes a piece behind it.

Discovered attack Moving a piece to reveal an attack by a line piece.

Back rank The first rank for White and eighth rank for Black.

Opposition An endgame king relationship where the player not to move often holds the direct face-off.

Repertoire A prepared set of opening choices for common opponent replies.

Theory Published and tested opening lines and explanations, which remain context-dependent.

Variation A branch of moves from a given position.

Luft An escape square for a king, often created by a pawn move.

Sources and verification notes

The curriculum structure and named opening descriptions are grounded in the publications below, checked November 11, 2026. Links are supplied so you can inspect the underlying course descriptions, opening encyclopedia entries and free practice resources yourself.

S01 The Steps Method — Manual Step 2

The published topic sequence: piece activity, double attacks, pins, discovered attacks, intermediate moves, opening rules, pawn endings.

https://www.chess-steps.com/978-90-77275-36-8-manual-step-2

S02 The Steps Method — Official overview

Six-step trainer-and-workbook structure with progressively harder exercises.

https://www.stappenmethode.nl/en/

S03 Chess.com — Study Plan: The Opening (Sam Shankland)

Opening principles, practical play, checking positions after move 10, and a few studied tournament openings.

https://www.chess.com/article/view/study-plan-for-beginners-the-opening

S04 Chess.com — How Lessons Work

Explanations followed by interactive challenges organized by level.

https://support.chess.com/en/articles/8609703-how-do-lessons-work-on-chess-com

S05 Chess.com Opening Encyclopedia — Italian Game

Definition, Giuoco Piano, Pianissimo, Two Knights, and main opening ideas.

https://www.chess.com/openings/Italian-Game

S06 Chess.com Opening Encyclopedia — Caro-Kann Defense

Defining moves and Classical, Advance, and Exchange variations; bishop-development ideas.

https://www.chess.com/openings/Caro-Kann-Defense

S07 Chess.com Opening Encyclopedia — Queen's Gambit Declined

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 definition and basic plans.

https://www.chess.com/openings/Queens-Gambit-Declined

S08 Chess.com Opening Encyclopedia — QGD Orthodox Defense

Published Orthodox move order and solid kingside development plan.

https://www.chess.com/openings/Queens-Gambit-Declined-Orthodox-Defense

S09 Lichess — Puzzle Themes

Definitions and targeted practice categories for forks, pins, skewers, checks, tactics, and opening puzzles.

https://lichess.org/training/themes

S10 Chess.com — MoveTrainer Spaced Repetition

Review intervals increasing with successful recall; mistakes shorten the intervals.

https://support.chess.com/en/articles/10319322-how-does-the-spaced-repetition-scheduling-work

S11 Susan Polgar Foundation — Free Chess Curriculum

A published beginner curriculum combining notation, opening principles, tactics and checkmating skills.

https://susanpolgarfoundation.org/free-curriculum/

S12 Chess.com Opening Encyclopedia — Caro-Kann Classical

Verified Classical move order and the ...Bf5 idea.

https://www.chess.com/openings/Caro-Kann-Defense-Classical-Variation

S13 Chess.com — The Queen's Gambit overview

Explanation of ...c5 as a common Black counterattack to White's central pawn chain.

https://www.chess.com/openings/Queens-Gambit

Source-to-lesson map

Lessons 1–4: S01, S09, S11. Lessons 5–6 and 16: S03, S04, S10. Italian lessons 7–9: S05. Caro-Kann lessons 10–11: S06, S12. QGD lesson 12: S07, S08, S13. Planning and endgame lessons 13–15: S01, S03, S09, S11, S13.

Notes on accuracy: Opening families have many legitimate branches, and an individual model line is not a complete repertoire. Some training positions are original compositions simplified to isolate a motif. The referenced course providers did not review this book. Copyrighted course chapters, diagrams and paid exercises were not copied.